

the 1990s, the number of people with a mental health problem has increased by 50% (Mental Health Foundation 2000). The prevalence of mental health problems in the UK is estimated to be 15% (Mental Health Foundation 2000).

There is a growing awareness of the need to address the needs of people with mental health problems. The Department of Health (2000) has set out a strategy for mental health care, which aims to improve the lives of people with mental health problems and to reduce the burden of mental illness on society. The strategy is based on three main principles: (1) to promote the recovery of people with mental health problems; (2) to provide a range of services to meet the needs of people with mental health problems; and (3) to ensure that people with mental health problems are treated with respect and dignity.

The Department of Health (2000) has also set out a number of key objectives for mental health care. These include: (1) to reduce the incidence of mental health problems; (2) to improve the early diagnosis and treatment of mental health problems; (3) to improve the quality of life of people with mental health problems; (4) to reduce the burden of mental illness on society; and (5) to ensure that people with mental health problems are treated with respect and dignity.

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